

The European Enlightenment

The Enlightenment was a period from the mid-17th to the early 19th centuries in which writers and thinkers from Europe questioned traditional beliefs about nature, religion, and society. Its aims were summed up in the words of German philosopher Immanuel Kant—“Dare to know!”—meaning that people should have the courage to think for themselves.

The European Enlightenment, sometimes called the Age of Reason, was influenced by the ideas of 17th-century French thinker René Descartes (see p.139), who argued that reason (logical thought) is the source of all knowledge, and that everything should be doubted until it could be proven. This inspired a new scientific approach to solving problems, and through devising experiments into natural phenomena, scientists such as Isaac Newton made breakthroughs that changed our understanding of the world.

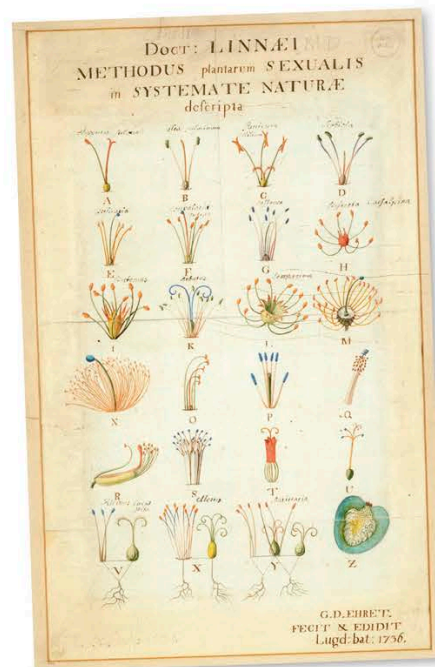
CHILD IN TIME

Even as a child, Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart (1756–1791) amazed audiences across Europe with his extraordinary musical skills. He went on to become the greatest classical composer of the era.



LANGUAGE OF SCIENCE ▼

Swedish biologist Carl Linnaeus created a binomial (two-name) classification system to describe every living creature, so that scientists writing in different languages could use the same names for plants and animals. Linnaeus presented his new system in his book *Systema Naturae* in 1735, and it is still in use today.



Political thinkers, meanwhile, argued about the way people live and how they should be governed. New ideas emerged about people's rights and equality, especially in politics and religion. They spread rapidly through coffeehouses and reading clubs, where people met to read newspapers and exchange views. In due course, some of these ideas would go on to inspire great changes and revolutions in some parts of the world.

▼ FREE SPEECH

French writer Voltaire was famous for his fearless defense of people's right to speak freely without being punished, and for opposing slavery. He used to meet other thinkers at his house to discuss ideas (below). Voltaire often poked fun at the Church and the government, and as a result was imprisoned twice, and spent nearly 30 years in exile.

Voltaire raises his hand to make a point.

